AsteroidSy and Macmillan showed a very cautious interest in my new first chapter of The Puzzle of Life. I began writing additional chapters to the latter and changed the name to avoid a too-philosophical interpretation of the subject of the book. I now called it The Chemistry of Life.

I also finished "The Pause," a short story involving a theme I had used before—the Earth under the control of much more advanced outsiders—and sent it off to Fred Pohl on November 13. I intended it for an anthology of original stories that he was editing.

3

On November 17, 1952, my mother called me. They had sold the candy store at Windsor Place, which they had possessed for one month

short of sixteen years. I had helped them run it the first six years, and Stanley had helped the last ten.

What's more, they were not buying a new one; they were retiring!

For twenty-six years altogether, they had labored in four different candy stores (five, if we count the brief stay in the Church Avenue store), and now it was all over. They were out from under the incubus that had kept them buried alive almost since they had come to the United States and that had distorted my own childhood.

It was time enough. My father was about to turn fifty-six, my mother had just turned fifty-seven, and they could count on $50 a week earnings (after taxes and maintenance) from their houses. Nor were their children any longer a drain on them. All three had jobs and could support themselves and I, at least, could pitch in and help if the old folks got into trouble—which they never did.

It was a queer feeling. I could just barely remember the days before the candy store, and if you discount those dim flashes of Van Siclen Avenue, all my life centered about a candy store till just before I was married, and even afterward I could never think of my parents without one. And now it was gone.

The whole candy-store interlude had lasted only a quarter of a century. I could have sworn it was eternal.

4

The final installment of The Currents of Space, in the December 1952